

"the" & "a"

Quick Reference Guide

Factors	The	A, an	[none] Some/"Silent Some"	[none] Possessive Noun/Pronoun	Examples	Comments
Focus of comment	narrow	broad	broad	o	The: Please focus on the tunnel of light. A: France is a nation among many. Possessive: They are our friends.	
Group size	small	big	big	o	A: Please show him a painting. The: Please show him the Van Gogh.	
Number in existence	Only one exists (in the context)	Many exist (in the context)	o	o	The: This is the Milky Way Galaxy. A: The is a grain of sand. Possessive: This is your island.	
Specialness	o	x	x	o	The: Naoto Kan was the prime minister. A: This is a goldfish.	
Mentioned already or not	already mentioned	not already mentioned	not already mentioned	already mentioned	A: A team of researchers in Belarus... The: The researchers found that....	
Countability	Uncountable - Specific	Countable	Uncountable - General	o	The: I'll have the red house wine, please. A: I'll have a cup. Silent "some": I'll have wine.	
Description: noun property quantitative/qualitative adj	quantitative noun quantity or quality e.g. tall vs.height:3cm	adjective quality e.g. tall	o	o-qualitative X-quantitative	The: Can you tell me the height? A: Please give me a tall one. Silent "some": I need (some) (more)length. silent "some": We need (some) tall kids. Pronoun: We need these tall cups.	Exception: trumped by identification.
Descriptive phrase: "It is _____ inexpensive X."	x-normal o-only for descriptions using an identifying phrase	o	o	o	A: These shoes are a little (bit) too tight (just) here." Was the green shirt a high quality shirt? The: This cup is the color of winter. Silent "some":They are inexpensive shoes.	
Specific identification:	o	x	x	o	A: Yes, I want the blue pair of shoes. Was the green shirt the low quality one?	Trumps Descriptions When specifying one present option, "the" may replace the normal pattern. Here "the" has the same meaning as "this," or "these"
Singular or Plural	plural	single	o	o	The: These are the three pens. A: This is a pen.	
Unit-Groups (pair, dozen)	x	o	x	o	A: I want a pair of shoes.	Exception: trumped by identification.

Table 1: Factors [For using "The" vs. "A" vs. "none" vs. "pronoun" vs. "possessive"]

The rule of the silent "some":

If you can say "**some**," then you can use **no-word**.

e.g. I am drinking water. = I am drinking **some** water.